

# The Great Barrier Reef

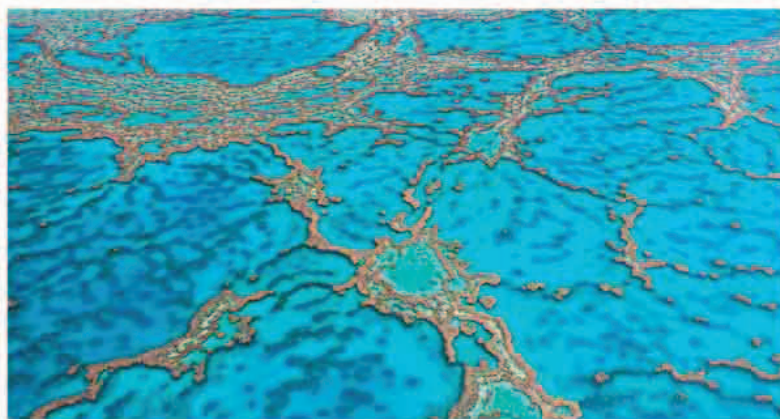
The biggest coral reef in the world is the Great Barrier Reef, which lies off the coast of tropical northeastern Australia. It is a vast complex of 3,000 coral reefs linked together in a chain of living coral rock 1,430 miles (2,300 km) long—the largest structure on Earth built by living things.

## OCEAN BARRIER

This spectacular reef gets its name because it acts as a barrier between the coast and the large waves of the open Pacific Ocean. It extends several miles offshore, to the edge of Australia's continental shelf. The water between the reef and the shore is relatively shallow, but beyond the reef, the depth drops down from near zero to 3,280 ft (1,000 m) or more.

### ► VIEW FROM SPACE

*This view from the International Space Station, orbiting 268 miles (431 km) above Cape Flattery in northeastern Australia, shows how the Great Barrier Reef forms an almost continuous ribbon of coral along the edge of the continental shelf.*



## CORAL COMPLEXITY

Although the reef makes an effective barrier against the huge waves of the Pacific, it is not a continuous wall of coral. The reef crests form a complex network of strong coral rock, enclosing thousands of small, shallow lagoons of clear blue water with soft beds of white coral sand.